

Kathryn James McGraw

Department of Leadership, Policy, & Organizations
Vanderbilt University, Peabody College
kathryn.e.mcgraw@vanderbilt.edu

EDUCATION	Vanderbilt University, Ph.D. Leadership & Policy Studies (exp.) 2027 University of Mississippi, M.A. Curriculum and Instruction 2019 University of Mississippi 2017 B.A. Economics, B.A. Public Policy, and B.A. Southern Studies <i>Summa cum laude, Phi Beta Kappa, Phi Kappa Phi</i> <i>Honors thesis</i>: "Disproportionality in Discipline and Achievement: Disparities in Mississippi's Public Schools."
PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS	Welsh, R.O. and James McGraw, K. (2025, February). Advancing Equity via Research-Practice Partnerships: A Theory of Action for Equity-Centered RPPs. <i>Frontiers in Education</i>. Special issue: Situating Equity at the Center of Continuous Improvement in Education Lebovitz, B., James McGraw, K., Muniz, D., Rasheed, Q., and Philips, C. (2026, August). Graduate Student Councils as Sites of Service, Strain, and Possibility: Addressing Organizational Disconnects. <i>Journal of Cases in Educational Leadership</i>.
MANUSCRIPTS UNDER REVIEW	Cox, A. and James McGraw, K.. (Under third review, <i>Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis</i>). Searching for Educational Equity: A Study of Racialized Decoupling in District Planning Documents. James McGraw, K. and Williams, T.R. (Under second review, <i>Teachers College Record</i>). "This is supposed to be a conversation": Racialized Institutional Logics and (Dis)Engagement in School Closure Deliberations. James McGraw, K. and Wood, De'Ja. (Under review). <i>Return to Zero Tolerance? State School Discipline Policymaking Post-2020</i>. James McGraw, K., Goldring, E., and Rubin, M. (Under review, <i>International Handbook of School Effectiveness and Improvement (2nd Edition)</i>). Beyond Short-Term Reform: Institutionalizing Sustainable District-Wide Improvement. (invited chapter) Shirrell, M., Becher, A., James McGraw, K., and Kaul, M. (Under review, <i>Oxford Handbook on Systems Transformation in Education</i>). Professions and Systems Transformation in Education: Jurisdiction, Collaboration, and Expertise. (invited chapter)
RESEARCH REPORTS & PUBLIC-FACING WRITING	James McGraw, K., Goldring, E.B., and Rubin, M. (2025). Building Principal Pipelines that Last. <i>Educational Leadership</i>. https://www.ascd.org/el/articles/building-principal-pipelines-that-last. Goldring, E.B., Rubin, M., and James McGraw, K. (2025). <i>Implementing for Sustainability: Principal Pipelines in Four Districts</i>. The Wallace Foundation. https://doi.org/10.59656/-EL-LS8611.001 Welsh, R.O. and James McGraw, K. (2025). <i>Stuck between a rock and a hard place? Disentangling the intersections of student behavior, school discipline, and school safety in the post-COVID era</i>. Boulder, CO: National Education Policy Center. https://nepc.colorado.edu/sites/default/files/publications/PB%20Welsh_1.pdf

WORKS IN PROGRESS

James McGraw, K.. *Accountability Policy as a Racialized Administrative Practice: The Case of Teacher Assignment.* Draft available upon request.

Wood, De'Ja and **James McGraw, K..** *Inclusive Discipline States or Eternal Discipline States? Interrogating Racialized Policy Discourses in States with Below-Average Rates of Exclusion.* Draft available upon request.

James McGraw, K.., Rubin, M., Goldring, E., Cox, A., Smith, G., and Herman, M. *Assistant Principals' Career Paths: The Role of District Policy and Practice Advancing or Constraining a Diverse Leader Corps.* Draft available upon request.

Cox, A., Goldring, E., **James McGraw, K..**, Smith, G., Herman, M., and Rubin, M. *District Human Resources Structures: Implications for principal pipelines and educators' career development.*

Goldring, E. and **James McGraw, K..** *Principal Evaluation Systems in a Changing Policy Context.*

James McGraw, K.. and Cox, A. *Examining Strategic Plans in Southern School Districts: A Natural Language Processing Approach.*

James McGraw, K.. *Racialized Social Control in Schools and Society: The State-level Relationship Between Exclusionary Discipline and Social Policy.*

Welsh, R.O., **James McGraw, K..**, and Williams, T.R. *The use of research evidence in school discipline: Towards leveraging an expanding literature.* Draft available upon request.

RESEARCH GRANTS

Bonsal Applied Education Research Award, PI, \$10,000 2026

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Assistant, Dr. Ellen Goldring Fall 2023–Present

Principal Pipeline Sustainability, The Wallace Foundation

Schoolteacher at 50, The Spencer Foundation, The Wallace Foundation, and The Walton Family Foundation

Graduate Research Assistant, Dr. Richard Welsh Spring 2023–Spring 2025

Research Practice Partnerships and Racial Equity in School Discipline, William T. Grant Foundation and AIR

Graduate Research Assistant, Dr. Jenn Russell Spring 2023–Spring 2024

Supporting Educators Working Group, Nashville Partnership for Educational Equity Research

Classroom Observation Scorer, Dr. Paul Steinle, AIR Spring 2023

MTSS-R Impact Evaluation Study

Policy Research Fellow, Teach Plus Mississippi 2021–2022

Teacher Licensure and Educator Pathways Working Group, supervised by Sanford Johnson

HONORS, AWARDS, AND FELLOWSHIPS

David L. Clark Scholar 2026

University Council for Educational Administration and Divisions A and L of the *American Educational Research Association*

Just Education Policy Institute 2025

Peabody College Fellowship 2022-2027

National Endowment for the Humanities Summer Institute Fellow 2021

National Board Certified Teacher: English Language Arts, Adolescent and Young Adult 2021

Mississippi Teacher Corps Academic Achievement Award 2019

	Holly Springs School District Teacher of the Year	2019
	Gray Award, Center for the Study of Southern Culture <i>Top disciplinary undergraduate research award</i>	2017
	University of Mississippi Taylor Medal <i>Top undergraduate award; awarded to fewer than 0.5% of students</i>	2016
	Stamps Scholar	2013-2017
TEACHING	Vanderbilt University: EHL 8810: Logic of Inquiry (Teaching Assistant)	Spring 2026
	ELP 8220: Educational Accountability & Student Assessment (Teaching Assistant)	Fall 2024
	Advocacy and the U.S. Policy Process (Instructor, rising 12th graders)	Summer 2023
SERVICE	University Council for Educational Administration, Graduate Student Council	2024-2027
	Senior Faculty-Student Representative, LPO Department	2024-2026
	Junior Faculty-Student Representative, LPO Department	2022-2024
	Cooperating teacher for preservice practicum, Mississippi College	2021-2022
	Truth, Racial Healing, and Transformation Teacher Circle, Millsaps College	2019-2021
REFeree	Conferences	
SERVICE	UCEA (GSS)	2023, 2024, 2025, 2026
	AERA	2025, 2026
	APPAM	2026
INVITED	James McGraw, K. (2025, June). <i>Implementing for Sustainability: Lessons learned from The Wallace Foundation's Principal Pipeline Learning Community initiative.</i>	
PRESENTATIONS	ASCD meeting, San Antonio, TX.	
PEER-REVIEWED	James McGraw, K.* and Williams, T.R. (2026, April). <i>Racialized Institutional Logics Advancing or Contesting School Closure.</i>	
CONFERENCE	American Education Research Association meeting, Los Angeles, CA.	
PRESENTATIONS	James McGraw, K.* and Cox, A. (2026, April). <i>Examining Strategic Plans in Southern School Systems: Where Do Educators and Equity Fit In?.</i>	
	American Education Research Association meeting, Los Angeles, CA.	
	James McGraw, K.* and Cox, A.* (2026, March). <i>Examining Strategic Plans in Southern Urban School Systems: A Natural Language Processing Approach.</i>	
	Association for Education Finance and Policy meeting, Chicago, IL.	
	Cox, A. and James McGraw, K.* . (2025, November). <i>Searching for Educational Equity: A Study of Racialized Decoupling in District Planning Documents.</i>	
	Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management meeting, Seattle, WA.	
	James McGraw, K.* and Welsh, R.O. (2025, November). <i>The State of Social Control: Exploring the Relationship between Exclusionary Discipline and Incarceration Across States.</i>	
	Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management meeting, Seattle, WA.	

James McGraw, K.* and Cox, A.* (2025, November). *Teacher Equity as District Policy: Examining Strategic Plans in Southern Urban School Systems*. University Council for Educational Administration meeting, San Juan, PR.

Goldring, E.B.* and **James McGraw, K.***. (2025, November). *The Next Generation of Principal Evaluation: Measuring Principal Effectiveness in a Changing Policy Context*. University Council for Educational Administration meeting, San Juan, PR.

James McGraw, K.* and Williams, T.R.* (2025, November). *Negotiated Narratives: An Examination of District Leader and Community Member Logics Advancing or Contesting School Closure*. University Council for Educational Administration meeting, San Juan, PR.

Cox, A.* and **James McGraw, K.***. (2025, April). *District Strategic Planning: Disrupting or Maintaining Racialized Burdens*. American Education Research Association meeting, Denver, CO.

Goldring, E.B., Rubin, M., and **James McGraw, K.*** (2025, April). *Learning to Sustain Improvement Initiatives: The Case of Principal Pipelines*. American Education Research Association meeting, Denver, CO.

James McGraw, K.*, and Williams, T.R.* (2025, April). *Competing Narratives: Contesting Value in School Closure*. American Education Research Association meeting, Denver, CO.

Welsh, R.O., **James McGraw, K.**, and Williams, T.R.* (2025, April). *The Use of Research Evidence and Disrupting Discipline Disparities*. American Education Research Association meeting, Denver, CO.

James McGraw, K.* and Welsh, R.O.,(2025, March). *The State of Social Control: Exploring the Relationship between Social Control Patterns in Schools and Society Across States*. Association for Education Finance and Policy meeting, Washington, D.C.

Welsh, R.O.*, **James McGraw, K.**, and Williams, T.R. (2025, March). *The Use of Research Evidence and Disrupting Discipline Disparities*. Association for Education Finance and Policy meeting, Washington, D.C.

James McGraw, K.*, Wood, D.*, and Welsh, R.O. (2024, November). *Return to Zero Tolerance? Examining State School Discipline Policy and Media Discourses in the Post-COVID-19 Era*. University Council for Educational Administration meeting, Los Angeles, CA.

Goldring, E.B., Rubin, M., and **James McGraw, K.*** (2024, November). *Learning to Sustain Improvement Initiatives: The Case of Principal Pipelines*. University Council for Educational Administration meeting, Los Angeles, CA.

James McGraw, K.* and Williams, T.R.* (2024, November). *Competing Narratives: Contesting Value in School Closure*. University Council for Educational Administration meeting, Los Angeles, CA.

Henrick, E.*, Welsh, R.O.*, and **James McGraw, K.**. (2024, July). *Tools and Routines Supporting the Use of Research Evidence in RPPs*. NNERPP Annual Forum, Richmond, VA.

James McGraw, K.*, Wood, D. and Welsh, R.O. (2024, April). *Return to Zero Tolerance? Examining State School Discipline Policy and Media Discourses in the Post-COVID-19 Era*. American Education Research Association meeting, Philadelphia, PA.

Wood, D.*, **James McGraw, K.**, and Welsh, R.O. (2024, April). *Disciplining Differently? Exploring States Beating the School Discipline Odds in the U.S.*. American Education Research Association meeting, Philadelphia, PA.

Cox, A.* and **James McGraw, K.***. (2024, April). *Leveraging Teacher Recruitment, Development, and Retention to Address Educational Equity Goals*. American Education Research Association meeting, Philadelphia, PA.

James McGraw, K. (2024, March). *State School Discipline Policy as a Tool of Racialized Social Control*. Association for Education Finance and Policy meeting, Baltimore, MD.

James McGraw, K.*, Wood, D. and Welsh, R.O. (2024, March). *Examining State School Discipline Policy in the Post-COVID-19 Era*. Association for Education Finance and Policy

meeting, Baltimore, MD.

James McGraw, K. (2023, November). *Teacher Allocation and Accountability As a Racialized Administrative Practice*. Association for Public Policy and Management meeting, Atlanta, GA.

James McGraw, K. (2023, November). *Teacher Assignment Patterns: How Accountability Sensitivity Is Moderated by Community Racial Identity*. University Council for Educational Administration meeting, Minneapolis, MN.

James McGraw, K. (2023, November). *Teacher Assignment Patterns: How Accountability Sensitivity Is Moderated by Community Racial Identity (GSS)*. University Council for Educational Administration meeting, Minneapolis, MN.

** Denotes presenting author*

AFFILIATIONS	Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)
	Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP)
	University Council for Educational Administration (UCEA)
	American Educational Research Association (AERA), Division L

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE	Mississippi Teacher Corps	
	Assistant Principal, Summer School	2019-2023
	Jackson Public Schools	
	English II Lead Teacher	2019-2022
	District High School English Professional Development Facilitator	2020-2021
	National Board for Professional Teaching Standards	
	Maintenance of Certification Scorer	2022-2024
	Holly Springs School District	
	English Department Chair & English II Teacher	2017-2019